

The Monkey's Paw

W. W. Jacobs · 1902

First published: Harper's Monthly, Sep 1902

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Lady_of_the_Barge/The_Monkey's_Paw (revision 15611995), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about fate and greed?
- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about be careful what you wish for?
- What does The Monkey's Paw suggest about grief?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Monkey's Paw	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*fate and greed* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Monkey's Paw

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about W. W. Jacobs's life or times connects to fate and greed in “The Monkey's Paw”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (fate and greed, be careful what you wish for, grief).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

W. W. Jacobs was born in Wapping, London, on 8 September 1863, where his father managed a wharf. He worked as a clerk in the Post Office Savings Bank while writing, and became popular for comic stories about sailors and dockside life, collected in volumes such as Many Cargoes (1896). He also wrote a handful of macabre tales; "The Monkey's Paw," in The Lady of the Barge (1902), is the most famous. He died in London on 1 September 1943.

Historical and cultural context

Late-Victorian Britain ran a global empire, and soldiers returning from India brought souvenirs and tales. The story's paw is from "an old fakir."

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Harper's Monthly in September 1902 and collected in The Lady of the Barge (1902).

Then: Very popular; adapted for the stage in 1903.

Now: A classic horror story about fate and wishes.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Sergeant-Major Morris gives the White family a monkey's paw that grants three wishes. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds.

Main themes

- fate.
- greed.
- grief.

Why it matters

It reminds us to be careful what we wish for.

Spoilers · teacher only

Their son Herbert dies at work, and the company pays exactly two hundred pounds. Mrs. White wishes him back; there is knocking at the door, and Mr. White uses the third wish.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Monkey's Paw: If you could have three wishes, what would you wish for?
Prompt: Before we open The Monkey's Paw: If you could have three wishes, what would you wish for?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
foreshadowing; suspense; irony; frame.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. W. W. Jacobs was born in Wapping, London, on 8 September 1863, where his father managed a wharf. He worked as a clerk in the Post Office Savings Bank while writing, and became popular for comic stories about sailors and dockside life, collected in volumes such as Many Cargoes (1896). He also wrote a handful of macabre tales; "The Monkey's Paw," in The Lady of the Barge (1902), is the most famous. He died in London on 1 September 1943. The world of the book. Late-Victorian Britain ran a global empire, and soldiers returning from India brought souvenirs and tales. The story's paw is from "an old fakir." Publication and reception. Published in Harper's Monthly in September 1902 and collected in The Lady of the Barge (1902). Then: Very popular; adapted for the stage in 1903. Now: A classic horror story about fate and wishes.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" slowly and put it in my own words: Morris explains that the man who enchanted the paw wanted to prove fate rules lives. Next, craft. I notice "ruled," a word of power and government, applied to fate. The strongest word is "ruled": it makes fate a ruler that punishes those who defy it. Then, effect. Why is this line a warning to the White family? My answer: Jacobs tells us the rule before the family breaks it, so we read the story with dread, watching them ignore the warning.

> *He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" slowly and put it in my own words: Morris explains that the man who enchanted the paw wanted to prove fate rules lives. Next, craft. I notice "ruled," a word of power and government, applied to fate. The strongest word is "ruled": it makes fate a ruler that punishes those who defy it. Then, effect. Why is this line a warning to the White family? My answer: Jacobs tells us the rule before the family breaks it, so we read the story with dread, watching them ignore the warning.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Sergeant-Major Morris gives the White family a monkey's paw that grants three wishes. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. Themes to track: fate.: greed.: grief.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: fate and greed. Prediction: Sergeant-Major Morris's warning about a paw that grants three wishes will be ignored by the White family. Question: what is the cost of trying to change fate?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Monkey's Paw: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: fate and greed. Prediction: Sergeant-Major Morris's warning about a paw that grants three wishes will be ignored by the White family. Question: what is the cost of trying to change fate?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Monkey's Paw still matter? It reminds us to be careful what we wish for.
Anchor question: Why might The Monkey's Paw still be taught today?
Facilitation: It reminds us to be careful what we wish for.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Jacobs worked as a clerk in the London post office and wrote this story in 1902, when stories of the British Empire in India were popular. Why might the paw come from India in a London story? Answer: Accept answers such as: British readers were fascinated by "exotic" magic from the colonies; the soldier brings it home from imperial service; the story mixes empire, superstition and fear.
Exit ticket: Jacobs worked as a clerk in the London post office and wrote this story in 1902, when stories of the British Empire in India were popular. Why might the paw come from India in a London story?
Answer: Accept answers such as: British readers were fascinated by "exotic" magic from the colonies; the soldier brings it home from imperial service; the story mixes empire, superstition and fear.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Monkey's Paw.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "W. W. Jacobs" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/W-W-Jacobs); W. W. Jacobs, The Lady of the Barge (1902) (https://www.gutenberg.org/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Verify the September 1902 Harper's date.

Lesson 2: The Monkey's Paw

Focus: wishes that defy fate

Objective: Students will analyze how foreshadowing develops in “The Monkey's Paw” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (death of a son, horror, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Death of a son; horror. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…fire, watched contentedly while his host got out whiskey and tumblers and stood a small copper k…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes death of a son; horror.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her husband wish Herbert alive. A knocking comes at the door; as she unbolts it, Mr. White uses the last wish, and the road outside is empty.

Background: Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service.

Significance: A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to fate because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes death of a son; horror.
Prompt: If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to fate because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: sideboard — a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top; dangling — hang freely; resounded — ring or echo with sound; coincidence — a chance happening that only looks planned; stumbling — walking unsteadily, nearly falling. "sideboard": Origin: an English formation from side + board. "coincidence": Origin: Middle French coincidence.
Words: sideboard: a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top · dangling: hang freely · resounded: ring or echo with sound · coincidence: a chance happening that only looks planned · stumbling: walking unsteadily, nearly falling

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service. A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it. Foreshadowing: The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror. Irony: The wish is granted exactly, and the money comes as compensation for Herbert's death. Suspense: The knocking at the door in the dark is drawn out while Mrs. White fumbles with the bolt, and Jacobs never shows what is outside. Watch for the paw: the temptation to control fate.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" slowly and put it in my own words: Sergeant-Major Morris says the holy man put a spell on the paw to show that fate rules people's lives. Next, craft. I notice the sentence states the story's warning plainly, almost like a moral at the start of a fable. The strongest word is "fate": it is the force the Whites will try to bend with their wishes. Then, effect. What did the old fakir want the paw to prove? My answer: The old fakir wanted the paw to prove that fate rules people's lives and that those who interfere with it suffer; so every wish the family makes is set up to go wrong.

> *He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" slowly and put it in my own words: Sergeant-Major Morris says the holy man put a spell on the paw to show that fate rules people's lives. Next, craft. I notice the sentence states the story's warning plainly, almost like a moral at the start of a fable. The strongest word is "fate": it is the force the Whites will try to bend with their wishes. Then, effect. What did the old fakir want the paw to prove? My answer: The old fakir wanted the paw to prove that fate rules people's lives and that those who interfere with it suffer; so every wish the family makes is set up to go wrong.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The wish seems modest (just enough to pay off the house), which makes the horrific way it is granted more shocking. Ask: How does this line connect to fate? Expected: The fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. (The wish.)

> *I wish for two hundred pounds (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The wish seems modest (just enough to pay off the house), which makes the horrific way it is granted more shocking.
Ask: How does this line connect to fate?
Expected answer: The fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. (The wish.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about wishes that defy fate? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Monkey's Paw develops the idea of wishes that defy fate. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. When the text says "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25), it shows this directly. The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.
Task: Annotate the story for foreshadowing, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about wishes that defy fate? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Monkey's Paw develops the idea of wishes that defy fate. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. When the text says "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25), it shows this directly. The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong? Ask: was Mr. White to blame, or was everything fated? Use the fakir quote.
Anchor question: If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?
Facilitation: Ask: was Mr. White to blame, or was everything fated? Use the fakir quote.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about wishes that defy fate? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. ("He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives", The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about wishes that defy fate? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. ("He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives", The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how foreshadowing shapes wishes that defy fate. Key takeaway: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Foreshadowing:** The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror.
- **Irony:** The wish is granted exactly, and the money comes as compensation for Herbert's death.
- **Suspense:** The knocking at the door in the dark is drawn out while Mrs. White fumbles with the bolt, and Jacobs never shows what is outside.

Themes and how they develop

- **fate:** the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow.

Symbols and motifs

- **the paw:** the temptation to control fate.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25) Theme.
- "I wish for two hundred pounds" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56) The wish.
- "frantically breathed his third and last wish" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141) The end.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow.
Evidence: "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25)
Reasoning: The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
sideboard (noun)	a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top	*There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*	"sideboard": Origin: an English formation from side + board. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/sideboard#Etymology)
dangling (verb)	hang freely	*He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.*	
resounded (verb)	ring or echo with sound	*A loud knock resounded through the house.*	
coincidence (noun)	a chance happening that only looks planned	*"Morris said the things happened so naturally," said his father, "that you might if you so wished attribute it to coincidence."*	"coincidence": Origin: Middle French coincidence. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/coincidence#Etymology)
stumbling (verb)	walking unsteadily, nearly falling	*She came stumbling across the room toward him. "I want it," she said, quietly. "You've not destroyed it?"*	

Discussion questions

1. If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?
2. Where does foreshadowing appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with fate and greed?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who brings the paw? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris
2. What did the fakir want the paw to show? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: That fate rules people's lives
3. What is the first wish? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two hundred pounds
4. How does the money arrive? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: As compensation for Herbert's death
5. What is the third wish implied to be? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: That the thing at the door go away
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Monkey's Paw" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her husband wish Herbert alive. A knocking comes at the door; as she unbolts it, Mr. White uses the last…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Monkey's Paw"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Monkey's Paw" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief…" What does "sideboard" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: sideboard: a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top.
10. Reread: "He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire." What does "dangling" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: dangling: hang freely.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Monkey's Paw" suggest about wishes that defy fate? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.
2. Find one example of foreshadowing in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: "He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives" (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25): Theme. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position

that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears.”, why might Jacobs have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Monkey's Paw”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Sergeant-Major Morris brings the Whites a mummified monkey's paw from India, cursed by a fakir to grant three wishes to three men. Mr. White wishes for two hundred pounds. The next day their son Herbert is killed in machinery at work, and the company pays two hundred pounds. Mrs. White makes her…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Monkey's Paw” set up that the rest of The Monkey's Paw will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56): The wish. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141): The end. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “If you had three wishes, what would you wish for? What could go wrong?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with fate and greed? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25): Theme. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in 1902 in Harper's Monthly; British readers knew India through soldiers like Morris returning from imperial service. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56): The wish. Theme

link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A classic of the horror tale that leaves its terror offstage; Gale's Short Stories for Students features it.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141): The end. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25): Theme. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Monkey's Paw” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56): The wish. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Monkey's Paw”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141): The end. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to be careful what you wish for: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Jacobs need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25): Theme. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the foreshadowing in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56): The wish. On foreshadowing: The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Monkey's Paw” treats wishes that defy fate with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Monkey's Paw see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141): The end. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve fate and greed? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25): Theme. On foreshadowing: The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about wishes that defy fate? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56): The wish. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask W. W. Jacobs about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Useful evidence: “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141): The end. Theme link: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Foreshadowing:** look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the first wish?
   A. Herbert's return
   B. Two hundred pounds
   C. A new house
   D. Long life

   Key: B (Two hundred pounds)
2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who brings the paw?
   A. Herbert
   B. Sergeant-Major Morris
   C. The company man
   D. A fakir

   Key: B (Sergeant-Major Morris)
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She came _____ across the room toward him. "I want it," she said, quietly. "You've not destroyed it?"” Word bank: sideboard, dangling, stumbling, resounded

   Key: stumbling
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25: “He _____ to show that fate ruled people's lives”

   Key: wanted
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56: “I wish for two _____ pounds”

   Key: hundred
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What did the fakir want the paw to show?
   A. That magic is good
   B. That fate rules people's lives
   C. That India is rich
   D. That wishes are free

   Key: B (That fate rules people's lives)
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the money arrive?
   A. As an inheritance
   B. In a letter from Morris
   C. As a lottery prize
   D. As compensation for Herbert's death

   Key: D (As compensation for Herbert's death)
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141: “_____ breathed his third and last wish”

   Key: frantically
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the third wish implied to be?
   A. That the thing at the door go away

B. For Herbert's happiness

C. To die

D. For more money

Key: A (That the thing at the door go away)

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The wish.

11. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Monkey's Paw”?

    A. Wishes that defy fate

    B. Endurance turning to justice

    C. Racial pride destroying love

    D. A woman's brief taste of freedom

    Key: A (Wishes that defy fate)

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Theme.

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Monkey's Paw”? The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror.

    A. Tone / mood

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Hyperbole

    Key: B (Foreshadowing)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Monkey's Paw”? The wish is granted exactly, and the money comes as compensation for Herbert's death.

    A. Theme

    B. Symbolism

    C. Irony

    D. Personification

    Key: C (Irony)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25).
    Sample answer: The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The wish.

17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The end.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how fate develops from an earlier story to “The Monkey's Paw”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Theme.
21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief…”, what does “sideboard” most nearly mean?
    A. a chance happening that only looks planned
    B. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
    C. hang freely
    D. ring or echo with sound

    Key: B (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top)
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.”, what does “dangling” most nearly mean?
    A. hang freely
    B. a chance happening that only looks planned
    C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
    D. ring or echo with sound

    Key: A (hang freely)
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Morris said the things happened so naturally," said his father, "that you might if you so wished attribute it to coincidence."”, what does “coincidence” most nearly mean?
    A. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top
    B. hang freely
    C. a chance happening that only looks planned
    D. ring or echo with sound

    Key: C (a chance happening that only looks planned)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	9, 3, 1, 4, 6, 8, 2, 5, 7, 11, 12, 10, 13, 14, 15, 17	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 2, 6, 4, 5, 9, 8, 3, 11, 12, 10, 18, 13, 14, 19, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 8, 7, 3, 6, 2, 9, 11, 12, 10, 14, 15, 13, 18, 20, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2

HS Senior	5, 4, 3, 7, 1, 8, 11, 12, 10, 18, 13, 14, 15, 17, 20, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 21, 6, 4, 9, 12, 11, 10, 18, 14, 13, 15, 17, 20, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	2, 6, 3, 5, 22, 12, 11, 10, 13, 18, 14, 15, 19, 20, 17, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	3, 23, 6, 7, 8, 11, 10, 12, 15, 18, 13, 14, 19, 16, 17, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	22, 5, 8, 9, 2, 12, 10, 11, 13, 18, 15, 14, 17, 19, 20, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	3, 2, 8, 9, 6, 10, 12, 11, 15, 18, 13, 14, 20, 19, 17, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	3, 2, 9, 4, 7, 10, 12, 11, 14, 13, 15, 18, 19, 16, 20, 17	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Monkey's Paw,” how does Jacobs show wishes that defy fate? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the foreshadowing you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In The Monkey's Paw, how does Jacobs develop the idea of wishes that defy fate? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the foreshadowing in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Monkey's Paw develops the idea of wishes that defy fate. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of foreshadowing and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (where it begins, turns and ends) and its foreshadowing shape the reader's understanding of wishes that defy fate. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what The Monkey's Paw suggests about wishes that defy fate. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's foreshadowing and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how W. W. Jacobs uses foreshadowing in The Monkey's Paw to complicate the reader's understanding of wishes that defy fate. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Monkey's Paw within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of wishes that defy fate responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Monkey's Paw alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of wishes that defy fate follows or bends those conventions, using the foreshadowing as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Monkey's Paw and its treatment of wishes that defy fate. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's foreshadowing and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Monkey's Paw as evidence for a larger claim about wishes that defy fate in The Monkey's Paw. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Monkey's Paw as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of wishes that defy fate. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Monkey's Paw.

SAT-style questions

1. *There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “sideboard” most nearly mean?

   A. a chance happening that only looks planned

   B. ring or echo with sound

   C. walking unsteadily, nearly falling

   D. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

2. *In the brightness of the wintry sun next morning as it streamed over the breakfast table he laughed at his fears. There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief in its virtues.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Monkey's Paw”?

   A. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   B. A family and a house collapsing together

   C. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   D. Wishes that defy fate

SAT key: 1. D (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top); 2. D (Wishes that defy fate)

Unit test

The Monkey's Paw: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141: "_____ breathed his third and last wish"
   Key: frantically
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56: "I wish for two _____ pounds"
   Key: hundred
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the money arrive?
   A. As an inheritance
   B. In a letter from Morris
   C. As a lottery prize
   D. As compensation for Herbert's death

   Key: D (As compensation for Herbert's death)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25: "He _____ to show that fate ruled people's lives"
   Key: wanted
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who brings the paw?
   A. Herbert
   B. Sergeant-Major Morris
   C. The company man
   D. A fakir

   Key: B (Sergeant-Major Morris)
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What did the fakir want the paw to show?
   A. That magic is good
   B. That fate rules people's lives
   C. That India is rich
   D. That wishes are free

Key: B (That fate rules people's lives)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the first wish?

   A. Herbert's return

   B. Two hundred pounds

   C. A new house

   D. Long life

   Key: B (Two hundred pounds)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the third wish implied to be?

   A. That the thing at the door go away

   B. For Herbert's happiness

   C. To die

   D. For more money

   Key: A (That the thing at the door go away)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “She came _____ across the room toward him. "I want it," she said, quietly. "You've not destroyed it?"” Word bank: sideboard, dangling, stumbling, resounded

   Key: stumbling

10. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Theme.

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The wish.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Monkey's Paw”?

    A. Wishes that defy fate

    B. Endurance turning to justice

    C. Racial pride destroying love

    D. A woman's brief taste of freedom

    Key: A (Wishes that defy fate)

13. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “frantically breathed his third and last wish” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 141). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The end.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25).

    Sample answer: The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Monkey's Paw”? The sergeant-major throws the paw into the fire, and his warning that the first owner's third wish was for death prepares the reader for horror.

    A. Tone / mood

B. Foreshadowing

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Hyperbole

Key: B (Foreshadowing)

16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Monkey's Paw”? The wish is granted exactly, and the money comes as compensation for Herbert's death.

A. Theme

B. Symbolism

C. Irony

D. Personification

Key: C (Irony)

17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The paw shows that meddling with fate brings sorrow.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

Sample answer: The fakir wanted to prove "fate ruled people's lives," and Mr. White's wish "for two hundred pounds" is granted through Herbert's death.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I wish for two hundred pounds” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 56) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: The wish.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how fate develops from an earlier story to “The Monkey's Paw”. Use one quotation from each.

Sample answer: the fakir's spell proves that interfering with fate brings sorrow.

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “He wanted to show that fate ruled people's lives” (The Monkey's Paw, paragraph 25) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Theme.

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Morris said the things happened so naturally," said his father, "that you might if you so wished attribute it to coincidence."”, what does “coincidence” most nearly mean?

A. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

B. hang freely

C. a chance happening that only looks planned

D. ring or echo with sound

Key: C (a chance happening that only looks planned)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He took the paw, and dangling it between his forefinger and thumb, suddenly threw it upon the fire.”, what does “dangling” most nearly mean?

A. hang freely

B. a chance happening that only looks planned

C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

D. ring or echo with sound

Key: A (hang freely)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “There was an air of prosaic wholesomeness about the room which it had lacked on the previous night, and the dirty, shrivelled little paw was pitched on the sideboard with a carelessness which betokened no great belief…”, what does “sideboard” most nearly mean?

    A. a chance happening that only looks planned

    B. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

    C. hang freely

    D. ring or echo with sound

    Key: B (a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “A loud knock resounded through the house.”, what does “resounded” most nearly mean?

    A. ring or echo with sound

    B. hang freely

    C. a long dining-room cabinet with a flat top

    D. a chance happening that only looks planned

    Key: A (ring or echo with sound)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Freshman	2, 1, 7, 4, 5, 3, 6, 9, 8, 12, 11, 10, 15, 13, 16, 14, 17, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Sophomore	5, 8, 1, 2, 6, 7, 9, 3, 4, 10, 12, 11, 15, 13, 16, 14, 17, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 1, 7, 8, 4, 2, 5, 3, 9, 10, 12, 11, 13, 16, 14, 15, 19, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	5, 7, 4, 9, 3, 6, 1, 8, 10, 11, 12, 15, 14, 13, 16, 19, 17, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	7, 3, 21, 9, 2, 5, 8, 10, 12, 11, 16, 14, 13, 15, 19, 18, 20, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	7, 1, 22, 23, 21, 9, 3, 11, 12, 10, 14, 16, 13, 15, 18, 17, 20, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 2, 24, 8, 22, 9, 6, 10, 11, 12, 16, 13, 15, 14, 17, 18, 20, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	9, 21, 2, 3, 7, 8, 6, 10, 12, 11, 16, 14, 15, 13, 20, 17, 18, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	3, 1, 21, 23, 22, 2, 7, 10, 11, 12, 14, 13, 16, 15, 18, 19, 20, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	9, 8, 23, 6, 2, 7, 21, 10, 12, 11, 16, 13, 14, 15, 19, 17, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Monkey's Paw: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how W. W. Jacobs develops fate and greed across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Monkey's Paw and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to be careful what you wish for.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Monkey's Paw. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Monkey's Paw finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of grief. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Fate and greed

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about fate and greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops fate and greed across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fate and greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fate and greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of fate and greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fate and greed in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Be careful what you wish for

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about be careful what you wish for. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops be careful what you wish for across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of be careful what you wish for. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of be careful what you wish for, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of be careful what you wish for in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on be careful what you wish for in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Grief

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Monkey's Paw teaches about grief. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how W. W. Jacobs develops grief in The Monkey's Paw. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how W. W. Jacobs develops grief across The Monkey's Paw. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Monkey's Paw (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of grief. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of grief in The Monkey's Paw. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how W. W. Jacobs's choices in The Monkey's Paw (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of grief, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Monkey's Paw's treatment of grief in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on grief in The Monkey's Paw that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on grief in The Monkey's Paw. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about grief in The Monkey's Paw, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on grief in The Monkey's Paw, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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